

ABSOLUTE JAFAR
By Sarnath Banerjee
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₹799; 272 pages

ON PAGE 100 OF SARNATH BANERJEE'S BRILLIANT NEW graphic novel *Absolute Jafar*, there's a full-colour, full-page illustration that belongs in art galleries and museums. The painting begins a chapter called 'Aman Ki Asha', referring to an erstwhile joint ad campaign for Indo-Pak peace, organised by two newspapers, one on either side of the border. *Absolute Jafar* depicts the whimsical trajectory and ultimate dissolution of an Indo-Pak marriage involving the book's narrator, Brighu, and Mahrukh. Jafar is their only son, a young boy who finds himself in the unenviable position of being both Indian and Pakistani. In the 'Aman Ki Asha' painting, Banerjee draws a large jacket with a zipper, only the 'teeth' of the zipper are actually human hands—locked in a tight handshake at the top of the jacket and diverging gradually until the hands at the bottom are no longer touching each other. It's an elegant way to depict the passage of time, especially within the context of a slowly unravelling marriage.

"Writers and artists are timekeepers, in one way or another," says Banerjee. "When you're writing a book, you're also trying to recreate the zeitgeist. Comic books have a specific relationship with time that's distinct from the prose novel—for starters, drawing forces you to slow down."

Longtime Banerjee readers will remember Brighu as the author and artist's recurring alter ego, first seen in his graphic novels *Corridor* (2004) and *The Barn-Owl's Wondrous Capers* (2007). The young Brighu, described as "a postmodern Ibn Battuta" in these books, is a flâneur walking the streets of Delhi, Calcutta and London in search of old books and other antiquarian knick-knacks. For the middle-aged Brighu, "badminton has replaced judo, irritation has replaced anger". But certain things haven't changed—for example, Brighu's attentiveness to the way societies stratify along class lines, something that has always been in your face in Delhi.

BRIGHU IS BANERJEE'S ALTER EGO, BUT HE IS ALSO A FULLY FORMED CHARACTER, COMPLETE WITH WELL-DEFINED MOTIVATIONS AND ANXIETIES

"When I was living in Delhi in the '90s and the early 2000s, there was a sense that there were a lot of possibilities, but those possibilities were not accessible to you," recalls Banerjee. "You would walk down the road and there would be music blaring from parties that you were not invited to.... And eventually you would walk down the same streets so many times that you would stop noticing them—the artist Paul Nash called this 'the blindness of the ordinary'."

As we move across Brighu and Mahrukh's stories in *Absolute Jafar*, we meet an unforgettable roster of characters—Tyagi the wily lawyer who negotiates the visa quagmire of an Indo-Pak long-distance relationship, or Sarabjit who becomes Mahrukh's alcoholic man Friday. A recurring theme is Brighu's tendency to see several of these figures in a religious light. On one page, Tyagi is drawn as a meditating Buddhist